



Making a Difference

Oommen wants student leaders to excel in studies. He led the way by bagging the prestigious Jawaharlal Nehru Memorial Doctoral Fellowship.

“MANY SEE STUDENT POLITICS AS A LAUNCHPAD TO Parliament. For me, the elevation to this post is a responsibility to further the causes I believe in.”

**GINU ZACHARIA OOMMEN,
STUDENT LEADER, 33**

His parents vowed to make him do something traditionally Christian, like being a priest. Years down the line, Ginu Zacharia Oommen is in anything but fabulous white gowns. He is a fledgling academic with several social science research works to his credit. His doctoral thesis on Jews who migrated to Israel from Kochi critiques the ethnic conflicts faced by the community from a Marxist perspective. And now he is making a mark in a larger arena: student politics.

Oommen, belonging to Kerala's Kottayam district, leads the All India Student Federation (AISF), the student movement of the CPI. His first exposure to politics happened when he joined Madras Christian College for post-graduation in political science. Oommen, now based in Delhi, matured into a student leader when he joined JNU for a PhD in International Studies. His Hindi speeches

were replete with jumbled genders, but his weighty baritone, English language skills and commitment to the cause helped. A year later, he went on to become the general secretary of the JNU Students' Union. By the time Oommen completed his doctorate in 2007, he was elected as the national president of the AISF. He made his mark as soon as he took over. Under him, the AISF took the lead in ensuring schools for children in riot-affected areas where students are rarely rehabilitated academically. "In urban areas, economic priorities like cellphone bills have taken over, forcing students to split their study time with BPO jobs. This is taking a toll on their academic life as well as meaningful political grooming," says Oommen.

As he sits cosily at the Café Coffee Day in Delhi's Connaught Place, he talks of his plans to take forward his movement—a bit like the way Café Coffee Day builds its coffee shops: everywhere. "At Utkal University, Orissa, the general secretary is from AISF. We are making inroads in Tamil Nadu, Orissa, Punjab, Manipur and Haryana." Recently, he partially fulfilled his parents' wishes by being the first Left youth leader to address the Maraman Convention in Kerala, Asia's largest assembly of Christians. He was treated to a standing ovation as he reminded them that Christian life has resonance in communist politics as Christ preached that it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of the needle than for a rich man to enter the Kingdom of God. Probably, nothing can better shake up insistent church-goers than the words of Jesus himself.

by Shafi Rahman